platform, coupled with the excitement of creating a global "Sunni Caliphate" and the spiritual experience of fighting for the glory of Islam'; (3) generational differences that have created a 'rift' between the older and younger generation (2018, pp. 329–30). Panjwani and Khimani (2018) espouse that five factors have coalesced to make the educated youth attracted to extremism: a) religion as a defining framework of the education system in Pakistan, b) the lack of humanities-based critical education, c) the lack of ideological alternatives to contemporary economic and social problems, d) the construction of Islam as a solution to modern problems by the Islamist ideology and e) global interactions of extremist discourse through social media (2018, p. 82).

General Qamar Javed Bajwa's speech at the youth conference and the interior minister's observation (see this book's introduction) point to a recognition of the ideological problems linked to extremism and terrorism, especially among the educated youth. The war against terrorism continues in Pakistan. However, the war has moved beyond the physical domain, with a counterextremism strategy that aims to 'connect' citizens to the state through a state-sponsored 'national narrative'.

The national narrative

The NCEPG emerged out of the National Internal Security Policy (NISP) 2014 (Ministry of Interior 2014) and were published in January 2018.[41] They aim 'to strike at the ideological cobweb of extremism and terrorist propaganda based on falsehood and distortions manipulated to serve their aim for spreading unrest and dissonance in society'. The approach is one that 'connects' the citizen with the state 'predicated on citizen inclusion and engagement' (NACTA 2018, p. 9). In an interview in 2016[42] Ihsan Ghani, the director general for NACTA, stated that there were different stages to terrorism, which included intolerance and extremism. In order to challenge extremism NCEPG focused on six areas of intervention[43]: (1) rule of law and service delivery; (2) citizen engagement; (3) media engagement; (4) integrated education reform; (5) reformation, rehabilitation, reintegration, and renunciation; and (6) promotion of culture.

The director general also highlighted the importance of average citizens in this fight against terrorism, extremism and intolerance; NACTA had set up a helpline (1717) that can be called to report any suspicious behaviour but also any hate speech that one might encounter, whether it be in a Friday sermon at a mosque or in reading material distributed on the streets (Outlook Pakistan 2017).